

CRUSADES



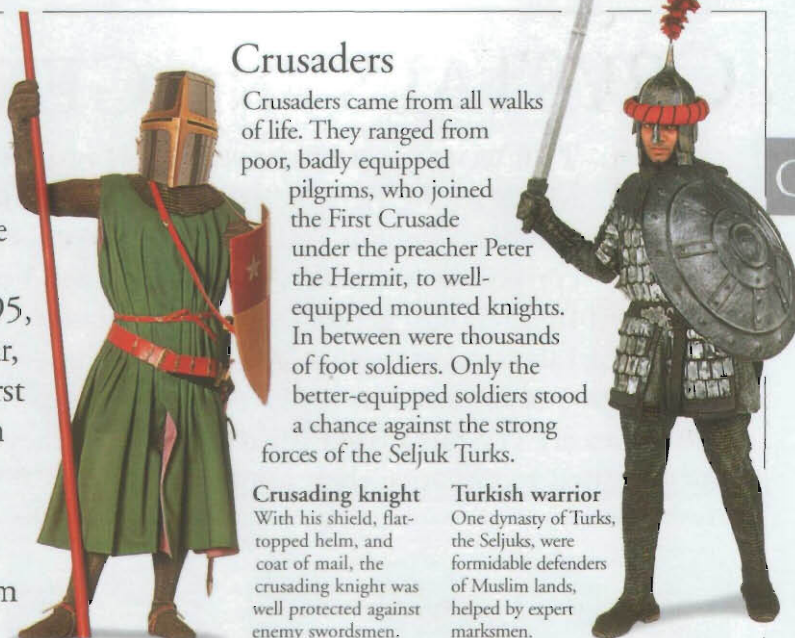
JERUSALEM HAD LONG been a place of pilgrimage for Christians from Europe, but by the 11th century the area was ruled by devoutly Muslim Turks, and pilgrims were often attacked. In 1095, Pope Urban II called for a crusade, or Holy War, to conquer Jerusalem for the Christians – the First Crusade. Over the next two centuries, a pattern emerged: Christians attacked and captured cities such as Jerusalem and Damascus, and the Muslims recaptured each one, until finally the crusaders lost all their territory and retreated from the Holy Land (Palestine) for the last time.

Crusaders

Crusaders came from all walks of life. They ranged from poor, badly equipped pilgrims, who joined the First Crusade under the preacher Peter the Hermit, to well-equipped mounted knights. In between were thousands of foot soldiers. Only the better-equipped soldiers stood a chance against the strong forces of the Seljuk Turks.

Crusading knight
With his shield, flat-topped helm, and coat of mail, the crusading knight was well protected against enemy swordsmen.

Turkish warrior
One dynasty of Turks, the Seljuks, were formidable defenders of Muslim lands, helped by expert marksmen.



Land and sea routes

The route from western Europe to Syria and Palestine was long and hazardous. Many travellers died from disease and hunger, and never saw the Holy Land. Sea travellers relied on trading cities, such as Venice and Genoa, to provide ships. The sea route was also far from safe – the Holy Roman Emperor Frederick I drowned while leading the Third Crusade.

1096–99
1147–49
1189–92
1202–1204

First Crusade

The crusaders journeyed across Europe, and took Antioch and Jerusalem. They then claimed lands throughout the area.

Second Crusade

After their earlier defeat, the united Muslims attacked Christians in the east. They captured Damascus, and routed the new French and German crusaders.

Third Crusade

In 1187, the great Saladin reconquered Jerusalem. Crusaders from England, France, and the Holy Roman Empire retaliated, but achieved only the capture of Acre.

Fourth Crusade

Sponsored by the pope, crusaders sailed to Constantinople, looted the city, and installed Baldwin of Flanders as emperor. They did not carry on to the Holy Land.



Children's Crusade

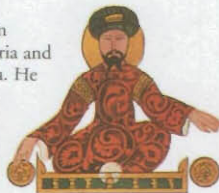
In 1212, thousands of children marched from the Rhineland to the Mediterranean. Most died of hunger or disease, and were caught and sold as slaves.

The spread of knowledge

The crusades increased contact between East and West, and helped take Islamic science and technology to Europe. Western medicine and architecture improved, although this may also have been due to contact with Muslims living in Spain.

Saladin

The brave Salah-ed-din (1138–1193) ruled Syria and part of northern Africa. He expelled the crusaders from Jerusalem in 1187, and ruled most of Palestine (modern Israel) from then on.



Richard I

King Richard I of England (the Lionheart) spent most of his reign (1187–1199) abroad. Despite victories on the Third Crusade, he never captured Jerusalem. After the Crusades, he was put in prison, ransomed, and spent his last years in France.



Windmills

Wind power was used in the eastern Mediterranean to provide power to grind corn, and crusaders may have taken the idea back to Europe with them. The first European windmills appeared in France in 1180.



Islamic medicine

Islamic medicine was well developed, and the writings of the Arabian physician Avicenna, or Ibn Sina (980–1037), were influential. Herbs were used as medicines. Myrrh was used for various infections, while balm of Gilead was used for chest and throat diseases.

Timeline

1096–99 First Crusade: The victorious armies establish first bases in the Holy Land.

1147–49 Second Crusade: Muslims retake Damascus; crusaders fail to retrieve it.

1189–92 Third Crusade: Christians take Acre, but Muslims keep Jerusalem.

1202–1204 Fourth Crusade: armies conquer Egypt, and loot Constantinople.

1218–21 Fifth Crusade: Crusaders capture land in Egypt, but fail to keep it.

1228–29 Muslims and Christians negotiate a truce which lasts 10 years.

1248–70 Seventh and Eighth Crusades.

1291 Muslims recapture the city of Acre, which is the last Christian stronghold in the Holy Land.



Templars

Originally a group of knights who protected Christian pilgrims, these men were given a base in the Holy Land in 1118. They became a religious order and took their name from their base near the Temple of Jerusalem.



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